

Monotropism

Autistic experience explained through attention — and what stops looking like defiance once you can see the tunnel.

Reach for it when transitions, “rigidity” or “obsession” are on the agenda.

Monotropism is a theory of Autism developed by Autistic people.

It explains Autistic experience through attention. Monotropic minds pull more of their attention into fewer things at a time, leaving fewer resources for everything else.

Once you can see the attention tunnel, a lot of what gets called defiance, rudeness, or obsession stops looking like any of those things.

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What This Is

- The mind works as an **interest system**. We are all interested in many things, and our interests direct our attention.
- In a **monotropic** mind, fewer interests are active at any one time, and each one draws more of the available processing.
- Attention behaves like a **tunnel**. Inside it, focus is deep and detail is vivid. Outside it, things get missed.
- Getting into a tunnel takes energy. Getting out of one takes more.
- Autistic, ADHD, and AuDHD people are more likely to be monotropic ([Garau et al., 2023 \(https://osf.io/wpx5g/\)](https://osf.io/wpx5g/)).
- Monotropism is a description, not a deficit. Whether it costs or pays depends heavily on the environment.

In a nutshell, monotropism is the tendency for our interests to pull us in more strongly than most people. It rests on a model of the mind as an '**interest system**': we are all interested in many things, and our interests help direct our attention. Different interests are salient at different times. In a monotropic mind, fewer interests tend to be aroused at any time, and they attract more of our processing resources, making it harder to deal with things outside of our current **attention tunnel**.

— Fergus Murray, [Starting Points for Understanding Autism \(https://oolong.medium.com/starting-points-for-understanding-autism-3573817402f2\)](https://oolong.medium.com/starting-points-for-understanding-autism-3573817402f2)

Where It Comes From

- The theory was set out by **Dinah Murray, Mike Lesser, and Wenn Lawson** in 2005, in *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism*.
 - Their starting claim is simple: the attention available to a person at any moment is limited, and mental processes compete for it.
 - **Fergus Murray** named the six starting points below in 2019, writing as a late-identified Autistic adult.
 - The **Monotropism Questionnaire** (Garau et al., 2023) was the first attempt to measure it. It was written by a group of Autistic adults from lived experience.
 - It is a **non-pathologising** theory. It describes how a mind distributes attention. It does not describe a fault.
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Six Starting Points

Fergus Murray's six starting points for making sense of Autistic experience. Each one follows from the same mechanism: the more a mind concentrates its resources in a few interests and concerns, the more we should expect these to be true.

1. Coping with multiple channels is hard

This can be sensory channels or other information streams.

- If attention is somewhere else, speech may not land at all.
- A conversation runs several channels at once — words, tone, gesture, eye contact, social context. Missing one is ordinary, not rude.
- Group settings multiply the channels. They cost the most, and they are usually where a day comes apart.

2. Filtering is tricky and error-prone

Sometimes things cannot be tuned out. Other times they are filtered out completely.

- Filtering is active work. It draws on the same resources as everything else.
- Filters get worse when a person is tired, stressed, or masking.
- Being able to **control** sensory input — rather than constantly filter it — gives that energy back.

3. Changing tracks is destabilising

Task-switching is hard, and new plans take work.

- Starting, changing direction, and stopping all cost energy. Autistic thought has inertia.
- Warnings, time, and recovery afterwards are the accommodation.
- A sudden change of plan means reorienting to everything about the new circumstances, not just the next task.

4. Things are experienced intensely

Usually things that relate to concerns and interests.

- Deep focus makes senses and detail more vivid. That runs both ways — more pleasure, more pain.
- Unexpected input is hard to ignore, even when it is small.
- Intensity is not overreaction.

5. Attention loops back to interests and concerns

It is hard to let things drop.

- Unresolved questions keep returning. Sonny Hallett calls these loops of concern (<https://medium.com/@sonnyhallett/loops-of-concern-ff792eebad03>).
- Asking again is not manipulation. The question has not settled.
- Interests are worth sharing rather than competing with.

6. What drops out of awareness tends to stay dropped

Reminders and visual aids help.

- Asking a hundred times does not work if it did not register the first time.
- A dropped task is not indifference. It is out of the tunnel.
- Checklists, timers, and visual prompts do the work that memory is being asked to do alone.

Reframing The Words

The same behaviour, described two ways. The second description is the one that leads somewhere useful.

Instead of	Consider
obsessions	passions
stuck on one activity	flow state and inertia
disengaged or not listening	juggling attention resources
repetitive behaviours	stimming to help regulate

What Helps At Home

Common challenges

- A loud, busy household
- Stress and anxiety around transitions — waking up, meals, day trips
- Executive functioning tasks like getting dressed or tidying a room
- Sensory and social overwhelm, arriving as meltdowns or shutdowns

What helps

- A safe space to rest, regulate, and be in their own interests

- Flexible routines rather than timetables
 - Extra time cushioning events, and fewer events in a day
 - Reliable times of day when interests are available
 - Visual reminders and checklists for the things that slip out of the tunnel
 - A low-demand approach after school, when there is nothing left
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What Helps At School

Common challenges

- Changes of teacher, room, or timetable
- Many transitions across a day
- A sensory environment nobody chose
- Executive functioning and memory demands — bags, homework, kit
- Meltdowns and shutdowns after sustained overwhelm

What helps

- Consistent staff, and preparation before any change
 - Flexibility and time around events to rest and recharge — and break time is often not rest
 - Sensory tools, chosen by the student: ear defenders, fidgets, movement
 - Visual reminders and timers, kept few enough to be usable
 - Interests woven into learning, and room for self-directed work
 - A topic-based curriculum where it is possible
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What This Does

- Explains sensory, social, communication, executive functioning, and wellbeing needs with one mechanism instead of a list of deficits
 - Turns "won't" into "the tunnel is somewhere else"
 - Gives a young person language for what is happening to them
 - Names the upside — flow, depth, focus, joy — alongside the cost
 - Gives families and staff something concrete to change: time, warning, quiet, and access to interests
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What This Does Not Do

- It is not a diagnosis. The **Monotropism Questionnaire is not an autism assessment**, whatever social media calls it.
 - It does not mean a person can only ever do one thing.
 - It does not license using interests as a reward, or removing them as a punishment.
 - It does not make monotropism a deficit, or polytropism a standard.
 - It is not universal. Fergus Murray describes these as common experiences, not a checklist every Autistic person will meet.
 - It is not exclusively Autistic. Monotropic experience is reported by non-Autistic people too, in varying degrees.
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Who This Is For

This may be useful if you:

- Are Autistic, ADHD, or AuDHD and want language for how your attention works
 - Are parenting or supporting a monotropic young person
 - Teach, and want to know why transitions and timetables cost so much
 - Are going into a meeting where a young person is being described as defiant, disengaged, or obsessive
 - Work in health or social care and meet monotropic people daily without a name for it
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How To Use This

You do not have to use all of it. Any one part helps.

1. **Name the mechanism.** "This is an attention thing, not a compliance thing" changes the conversation.
 2. **Buy time around transitions.** Warning, then time, then recovery. In that order.
 3. **Protect one tunnel a day.** Uninterrupted time in an interest is regulation, not a treat.
 4. **Move the reminder out of their head.** Checklists, timers, and visual prompts, kept few.
 5. **Fix the environment before the person.** Most of what looks like a skills gap is a sensory or transition load.
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Questions To Ask In The Room

Load

How many transitions does this day ask for, and which ones can go?

Warning

What notice does this young person get before a change, and who is responsible for giving it?

Recovery

Where can they go afterwards, and is it actually available to them?

Interests

Is their interest built into the day, or held back as a reward for compliance?

Attribution

When we write "refused" or "non-compliant," could we as easily write "was in a different attention tunnel"?

Quick Summary

Fewer things at a time, and more attention on each.

Attention behaves like a tunnel. Inside it there is depth, detail, and flow. Outside it, things get missed. Moving the tunnel costs energy, and most of the distress attributed to Autistic people comes from being moved constantly, without warning, in an environment nobody designed for them.

Further Reading

Recommended in *An Introduction to the Theory of Monotropism* by Fergus Murray and Helen Edgar:

- Beardon, L. (2025). *Reasonable Adjustments for Autistic Children: How to Make Their World Better*. Sheldon Press.
- Davis, R., O'Neill, C., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2025). *It Takes All Kinds of Minds: Fostering Neurodivergent Thriving at School*. Routledge.
- Dymond, K. (2025). *Creating a Neurodiversity-Affirming Classroom*. Jessica Kingsley Publishers.

- Edgar, H. (2023). *Embracing Monotropism and Supporting Young People To Help Prevent Autistic Burnout*.
- Edgar, H., & Gray-Hammond, D. (2026). *Re-Storying Autism. A Framework For Families, Parents, And Carers: Reimagining Support For Autistic People*.
- Elphinstone, K. (2024). *How to Raise Happy Neurofabulous Children: A Parents' Guide*. Jessica Kingsley Publishers.
- Murphy, K. (2025). *Neurodiversity-Affirming Practices in Early Childhood*. Routledge.
- Wharmby, P. (2026). *An Autistic Education: How Autistic Children Can, and Should, Thrive in School*. Vermilion.
- Wood, R. (2019). *Inclusive Education for Autistic Children*. Jessica Kingsley Publishers.

Signposting

1. monotropism.org (<https://monotropism.org/>) — Fergus Murray's collection of monotropism research and resources, including the archives of [Dinah Murray's work](https://monotropism.org/dinah/) (<https://monotropism.org/dinah/>). See also [Monotropism at School](https://monotropism.org/school/) (<https://monotropism.org/school/>).
2. [autisticrealms.com](https://www.autisticrealms.com/) (<https://www.autisticrealms.com/>) — Helen Edgar's site, with neuro-affirming resources to support Autistic people.
3. autismunderstood.co.uk (<https://autismunderstood.co.uk/>) — a site designed by Autistic young people, for Autistic people.
4. [Take the Monotropism Questionnaire](https://patterns.com/psychometrics/mq/) (<https://patterns.com/psychometrics/mq/>) — a reflective instrument, not a diagnostic test.

References

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2. Murray, F. (2019). Starting Points for Understanding Autism. *Medium* (<https://oolong.medium.com/starting-points-for-understanding-autism-3573817402f2>). Republished by [Thinking Person's Guide to Autism](https://thinkingautismguide.com/2019/02/starting-points-for-understanding-autism.html) (<https://thinkingautismguide.com/2019/02/starting-points-for-understanding-autism.html>).
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5. Leatherland, J. (2018). Understanding how autistic pupils experience secondary school: autism criteria, theory and FAME™. Doctoral thesis, Sheffield Hallam University.
<http://shura.shu.ac.uk/23231/> (<http://shura.shu.ac.uk/23231/>)
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 8. Murray, F., & Edgar, H. (2026). *An Introduction to the Theory of Monotropism To Support Autistic Young People*. Autistic Realms. <https://autisticrealms.com/product/an-introduction-to-the-theory-of-monotropism/> (<https://autisticrealms.com/product/an-introduction-to-the-theory-of-monotropism/>)
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Source And Attribution

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The six starting points are taken from ‘**Starting Points for Understanding Autism**’, written by **Fergus Murray, January 2019**. It can be found on their Medium page (<https://oolong.medium.com/starting-points-for-understanding-autism-3573817402f2>), and has also been republished by Thinking Person's Guide to Autism (<https://thinkingautismguide.com/2019/02/starting-points-for-understanding-autism.html>).

The underlying theory was formulated by **Dinah Murray, Mike Lesser, and Wenn Lawson**.

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This Why Sheet was developed by Fergus Murray, Helen Edgar, and Ryan Boren for Stimpunks Foundation.

Where this sheet comes from. It is written and revised as Markdown in the open: [Monotropism.md](#). That file is the source this page and its PDF are both generated from, so the three cannot say different things.

This sheet is also published as a page on [stimpunks.org](#).

There is a [one-sheet broadside](#) of this argument — the version you pin up.